

Assignment 2: Leadership Ethics

The 1996 Mount Everest disaster as detailed in the Harvard Business School case study, serves as a grim classroom for leadership ethics. In the “death zone” above 8000 meters, the margin for error is non-existent. The tragedy, which claimed the lives of seasoned guides including Rob Hall and Scott Fischer, was not merely a result of a freak storm, but a culmination of ethical lapses, and systemic leadership failures. Below I discuss three major ethical challenges faced by the leaders and propose the ethical decision I would have made in their position.

Ethical Challenge 1: The “Sunk Cost” Dilemma vs. Safety Rules

The most critical ethical failure was the violation of the predetermined turnaround time. Both leaders had established the importance of a strict turnaround time –Fischer’s famous “Two O’Clock Rule” stated, “If you aren’t on top by two, it’s time to turn around”. Similarly, Hall had “lectured us repeatedly about the importance of having a predetermined turnaround time”. However, on summit day, Hall never designated a final hard deadline, leaving it “vaguely articulated”. When 2:00 PM arrived, many clients had not reached the summit. Hall and Fischer faced the ethical challenge of upholding safety protocols against the “sunk cost” of their clients’ immense financial investment (\$65000 for Hall’s clients) and physical effort. By allowing climbers like Doug Hassen to proceed past a safe return time because they had “put too much of myself into this mountain to quit”, the leaders prioritized client satisfaction and emotional pressure over the fundamental ethical duty of non-maleficence (do no harm).

Ethical Challenge 2: Commercial Interests vs. Duty of Care

The rivalry between Hall’s Adventure Consultants and Fischer’s Mountain Madness introduced a dangerous commercial dynamic. Both leaders were under immense pressure to get clients to the top to secure media attention and future business. Hall had negotiated advertising space in Outside magazine in exchange for journalist Jon Krakauer’s fee, while Fischer recruited socialite Sandy Pittman to generate publicity. This created a conflict of interest where business objectives clouded professional judgement. Fischer explicitly noted the need to build a “yellow brick road to the summit” to prove that experience was overrated. The ethical challenge here was maintaining professional integrity in the face of commercial competition. The presence of high-profile clients likely added implicit pressure to succeed, potentially influencing decisions to push harder than conditions allowed, failing to insulate safety decisions from business goals.

Ethical Challenge 3: Hubris and The “Invincibility” of Leadership

Ethical leadership requires humility and the recognition of one’s own limitations. Both Hall and Fischer exhibited hubris that endangered their teams. Fischer was visibly exhausted from logistical problems and a recurring illness yet refused to turn back or delegate effectively. Hall bragged that he could get “any reasonably fit person to the summit”. The ethical challenge here

was the suppression of ego. A leader has an ethical obligation to remain fit to command. By ignoring their own physical deterioration and believing they could “conquer” the mountain regardless of the rules, they failed in their duty to lead effectively. Fischer, serving as the “sweep,” was too weak to assist struggling clients or enforce the turnaround, while Hall remained with a client far too long, dooming them both.

If I were the leader in this scenario, the best ethical decision would be the strict enforcement of the 2:00 PM turnaround rule, regardless of proximity to the summit.

From a deontological ethical perspective, rules created for safety are absolute duties that must be followed. As a leader, my primary contract with the client is not to guarantee a summit, but to guarantee the highest probability of survival. At 2:00 PM, I would order the turnaround. If a client like Doug Hansen pleaded to continue, I would have to exercise assertive authority, prioritizing his life over his ambition. As Hall himself noted before the climb, “My word will be the absolute law... I will tolerate no dissension up there”. I also would accept the commercial loss. As the case notes regarding Swedish climber Goran Kropp, turning around shows “incredibly good judgement”. A failed summit is a financial setback; a dead client is an irreversible tragedy and a total moral failure. Lastly, I would have set a hard time (e.g., 1:00 PM or 2:00 PM) before leaving Camp IV, removing the ambiguity that allowed the disaster to unfold.

The Everest tragedy teaches us that ethical leadership is not about heroism; is it about discipline. The “demanding classroom” of the Himalayas reveals that when leaders allow external pressures—money, ego, or competition to override established safety protocols, the consequences are catastrophic. True leadership ethics involves making the unpopular decision to turn back when the risks outweigh the benefits, valuing human life above all other metrics of success.